



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 18

KENTUCKY

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Kentucky's family courts and child-welfare system.

52

KENTUCKY FAMILIES ON RECORD · 62
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 24 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 29, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
22 OF 120

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

KENTUCKY AT A GLANCE.

Across 52 Kentucky families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 62 51 of 52 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$10,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 24 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 44.2% 28.8% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 52	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.2	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 51 of 52	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 22

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Kentucky families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF KENTUCKY FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	31	\$10,000	\$113,735	\$3,525,800
Lost Wages	23	\$5,000	\$68,839	\$1,583,300
Other Court Fees	23	\$1,000	\$8,922	\$205,200
Therapy / Evaluations	25	\$800	\$9,282	\$232,050
Reunification Services	15	\$400	\$6,527	\$97,900
GAL Fees	20	\$950	\$7,982	\$159,650
Asset Loss ¹	25	\$29,874	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$48,024	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$29,874) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		24	2 yrs
Mean months lost		38	3.2 yrs
Total across all families		1,286	107.2 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · KENTUCKY

Most families documenting in Kentucky are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Not provided		20	38%
Active case: stuck or delayed		18	35%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		7	13%
Case closed: within last 2 years		5	10%
Active case: progress being made		1	2%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		30	58%
Family Court Only		10	19%
Unknown		9	17%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		2	4%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		1	2%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		10	19%
Over 10 years		8	15%
3 – 5 years		6	12%
Less than 6 months		6	12%
5+ years		6	12%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		23	44%
50/50 Joint		10	19%
Visitation Only		7	13%
Children in Foster Care		5	10%
Full Custody		3	6%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Jefferson		6	12%
Breckinridge		2	4%
Franklin County And Mercer		2	4%
Spencer		1	2%
Marshall		1	2%
Pulaski		1	2%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		13	25%
Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		12	23%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		5	10%
Other: (Short answer)		3	6%
High Conflict Divorce		3	6%

05 PARENT VOICES — KENTUCKY

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Kentucky comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



They have destroyed my children and family. They almost took my and their father's life

— PAMELA

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

GALs or any third party appointed personnel cannot legally force you to pay for their services without a contract. Most are wholly inadequate to provide therapeutic or decide any sort of attachment bond between you and your children. Attorneys are not better parents or mental [...]

— KENTUCKY PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM KENTUCKY

Protected my abuser while causing me and my children more trauma.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has destroyed the lives of me and my children. My children currently live with their abusive father and I have no contact.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The Family Court has destroyed my entire life, separated me from my children and I was their primary caregiver, litigated me into destitution and I am at imminent risk to lose my home from delays and stalling. The judge is incompetent. Opposing counsel is now an accomplice- if [...]

— JENIFER

It has caused severe trauma and loss, emotionally and financially for my family. The excessive stress has also manifested as physical illness.

— VIVIAN

The system ruined my life and stole my relationship with my children, completely

— KEVIN

“The system has emotionally drained us.” The system took my baby when I fought so deeply.”

— TRAVONNA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



This wicked system has stolen something priceless that my son and I can never get back. It has inflicted trauma and irreparable harm for no legitimate reason. This injustice is inhumane.. we feel like we are in the twilight zone.

— EMILY

Tore our family apart. Broken our children

— ASHLEY

Destroyed us, mentally, emotionally & financially!

— BRITNY

They destroyed me and my family

— DANNY

It makes me wonder if my kids are even mine. Where is the accountability for family court actors?

— KAYCEE

My daughter is traumatized Omy whole family is, she believes shes never coming home and wants to give up

— VELENA

‘Through prolonged delays, silenced voices, blocked access to the courts, and unchecked power, the system dismantled our family not by justice, but by process—leaving my children separated and a parent unheard.’

— JESSICA

The system has failed ne and my family and most of all failed my kids

— JASON

Traumatized my kids, their therapist stated she needed to teach my 10yo to be a survivor, to be able to survive the abuse by his dad bc the court keeps giving him unsupervised visitation. Medical issues, anxiety, ptsd, issues with schools that were supposed to be their safe [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My children have intentionally and forcefully been neglected and abandoned by removing me from their life.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Severed what was a strong bond between my children, myself, and my fiancéeI. Prevented healthy discussion and understanding for my kids to understand that they were not abandoned by me and that this is not a reflection of their worth.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Im still in therapy. Now in spravato and emdr, my youngest has abandonment issues and major anxiety, now pooping his pants, he has major separation anxiety from me. My older sons were completely brain washed. My ex now has control over their minds as well as they are very [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Alienation of the children from a loving father and stepmother

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

There is no constitutional reason to remove a parent from a child. All allegations of child abuse should be tried in criminal court, perjury should carry a high price. Abolish this Racketeering across our country.

— JESSICA

Stole precious time, created permanent psychological scars that can heal but will never go away, and completely broke our trust in the government.

— DEIDRA

removed me from my children's daily lives during the exact years their clinical records now show caused them measurable, documented harm: separation trauma, maximum-score separation anxiety, and a mood disorder diagnosed by two independent licensed clinicians who both concluded [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

We r living in family court hell

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Withheld granddaughter from her family other sister because of lies. Wouldn't let granddaughter be with her sister because I (grandmother) exposed cps 2 years sooner .

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Tore us apart forever

— RICHARD

The system has accepted my ex wife's EPO against me for her and the children that was written in retaliation for me being done with her after 17 years of trying. It's been 8 months of the system separating me from my 5 children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



scared our minds forever, family problems with inlaws too much too list

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed. My sons are now brainwashed and alienated from me when I was the one accused of coaching and alienating them from their father because the didn't want to live with him.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Cause great damage. These people do not know what they are doing...

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my relationship with my children, used me for title four funding as a baby, then targeted my children because they knew I had no family. My six year old daughter (who i am just fine to parent) doesn't know her siblings, and they have been turned against me. Its like [...]

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No steps towards reunification with my children despite completing my case plan for over a year. Visits have stayed at minimum since they were taken 2 hours every other week, I've requested increased visitation and in-home visitation supervised or unsupervised. Called urgent [...]

— SARAH I

34 Kentucky parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 34 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — KENTUCKY

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Kentucky families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

GALs or any third party appointed personnel cannot legally force you to pay for their services without a contract. Most are wholly inadequate to provide therapeutic or decide any sort of attachment bond between your and your children. Attorneys are not better parents or mental health providers, and the majority of “therapists” are not qualified for high conflict cases, especially if alienation or attempts at false abuse allegations are made. Judges who sign off on motions without due process hearings from these self appointees are lazy and incompetent. Please find a new job, this is not a good fit for you.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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Im still in therapy. Now in spravato and emdr, my youngest has abandonment issues and major anxiety, now pooping his pants, he has major separation anxiety from me. My older sons were completely brain washed. My ex now has control over their minds as well as they are very misbehaved and prior to this my middle.son was about to be baptized. We were active in church, not now. My oldest quit all sports. I cant say anything without my kindness being taken out of context that I want my ex back. I cant have our oldest sons location hes now a driver but im not allowed to because my ex says I want her location and the judge said I have to have permission. We cant even co parent at this pointm she still harassed me. I can't even move on in a relationship she gets involved or starts messagaing.she involved and turned my whole family all our friends and my town against me which I was a major asset to this community she has ruined my life and totally changes the structure of our children's lives they have lived for over 10 years.... well simply because she has a new boyfriend. And ahe also did this to her ex husband prior to me... which the courts new! He became a drunk i believe now because of her control and narcissistic behaviors as well as her BPD he took off and left his oldest 2. Which is how I have 3.yes I adopted her kids 1 year prior to her then taking them... she wanted child support.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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removed me from my children's daily lives during the exact years their clinical records now show caused them measurable, documented harm: separation trauma, maximum-score separation anxiety, and a mood disorder diagnosed by two independent licensed clinicians who both concluded the cause was the separation itself, not my conduct. Every month I was restricted to supervised visitation while that unamended registry KARES listing cost me employment and income was a month my children went without their mother during a period that cannot be recovered — and the record of what that absence did to them is now in signed clinical notes from providers who had no connection to this case and no reason to reach any conclusion except the one the evidence gave them.

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No steps towards reunification with my children despite completing my case plan for over a year. Visits have stayed at minimum since they were taken 2 hours every other week, I've requested increased visitation and in-home visitation supervised or unsupervised. Called urgent care with no release of information signed, violating my privacy.

— SARAH I

34 full approved Kentucky comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT**WHAT THIS IS**

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Kentucky report comes from Kentucky respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Kentucky — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 52 Kentucky families reporting here are not the universe of Kentucky families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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